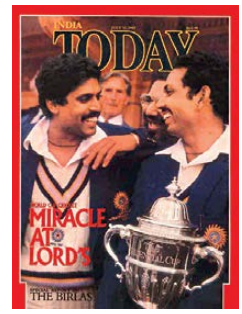
FROM THE

EDITOR-IN-CHIEF

The South African stand-up comic Trevor Noah has a disarming way of picking on the world's follies and funny accents. His topics can be dead serious, and you could die laughing listening to his post-mortems. When he landed in India last week, Noah ribbed audiences about the present spree of renaming or changing everything of colonial origin, saying, "We want to change the names of our cities and maybe even our country, but we don't want to get rid of cricket. Oh no, no, no, not cricket. Not everything the Britishers did was all that bad, after all." In a funny way, Trevor was right. We might have a conflicted relationship with all things foreign, but cricket has put down roots and gone native. It is now seen as thoroughly and totally Indian. And when we host the 2023 edition of the Cricket World Cup over six passion-filled weeks beginning October 5, we will behave as if it's a homecoming. All our innate skills at pageantry will be on display in what will surely be the planet's biggest sporting jamboree outside of the Football World Cup and the Olympics. A cumulative live audience of well over 2 billion is expected to watch the 48 games as the circus moves across 10 venues, over 45 days. The total prize money at stake is $10 million—the winners alone will take home $4 million. Will that be the Boys in Blue?



July 15, 1983

It has been a while. The last time we won was in 2011, under Mahendra Singh Dhoni's captaincy. Those dozen years of drought seem like a lifetime, but the gap before that was thrice as long. The epochal win by Kapil Dev's team in 1983 seems like such a settled fact of cricket history now that we tend to forget how utterly unexpected it was when it happened. INDIA TODAY has a kind of umbilical link with the Cricket World Cup: the first edition of both the magazine and the championship came in 1975. Eight years later, India were still so much the minnows—and the one-day format still not so much out of its infancy—that it was a holidaying correspondent who covered it for us. That win changed everything. The game's centre of gravity slowly but surely shifted towards the subcontinent, with India driving much of the money and the madness. One-day internationals (ODIs) attained a kind of centrality that they still have. Test cricket began to look more and more like a relic from the pre-industrial past, and its spectatorship shrank to the purists. T20, on the other hand, shrank cricket itself to the size of a tweet. The 50-over format had a balance of both the classical and the pop, the arts and the entertainment. The Cricket World Cup, as it is revealingly called, is therefore still the game's greatest showpiece—the G20 of cricket.

India's quest for the Cup of '23 rests on an exciting wager in terms of team composition. The situation is somewhat analogous to what we had in 1983. Kapil's Devils were an unlikely Ocean's Eleven who got together for the biggest heist in the world. As the skipper himself told INDIA TODAY in a post-match interview, sipping champagne, "It was the fielding that got us the Prudential World Cup." Twenty-eight years later, fielding had gone from being a lucky accident to a basic feature; fitness had become a professional affair. But Dhoni's team was one that had a world-beating swag, with a good sprinkling of the best—giants like Sachin Tendulkar and Virender Sehwag, swashbucklers like Yuvraj Singh, a steely Gautam Gambhir, besides a handful of colts. Dhoni's granite resolve was writ large on the way they were soldered together into a winning combination. The onus of repeating that feat, with a rather greener blend, now falls on Rohit Sharma.

The present squad of 15 is nearly two parts dew-fresh youth, one part experience. Virat Kohli and Ravichandran Ashwin are the only survivors from the 2011 team, and the latter isn't fully confirmed yet. The captain himself is the only other A-lister from the past. In short, it's a team built largely around a generation that grew up with the IPL—12 out of the 15 have played under 100 ODIs each, six have played under 50, and the back-up wicket-keeper Ishan Kishan (who Sourav Ganguly thinks should be first choice) has 18 matches in all. But players like Shubman Gill (35 caps), Mohammed Siraj (29), Shreyas Iyer (46), Suryakumar Yadav (29) and Shardul Thakur (44) have got the world sitting up and taking serious notice. Their forays into the 50-over format have already seen spectacularly fruitful moments. And they are as central to the team as the stalwarts and relative veterans like Ravindra Jadeja, Mohammed Shami, Jasprit Bumrah, K.L. Rahul and Hardik Pandya.

What they lack, crucially, is big match experience. It will be fascinating to watch how they shape up against the same teams they have excelled against in one-on-one series—say, an Australia or a Sri Lanka—within the high-stakes format of an international tournament. Outside of India, Australia and England are the two teams to watch out for. The latter, under the sway of their Test coach Brendon 'Baz' McCullum, have universally adopted a spunky version of cricket called 'bazball', which involves playing positively and attackingly regardless of match situation. New Zealand are the dark horse. And Pakistan still have that mercurial capacity to come out of nowhere and knock the best to the ground on their day—they also have captain Babar Azam, one of the best batsmen in the world. As we all know, India-Pakistan matches become a quasi-final unto themselves, with collective hysteria breaching the circuit barrier.

We have lined up a mini feast for you. A detailed SWOT analysis of the India team will aid those who came in late to the game. Sunil Gavaskar and Rajdeep Sardesai offer their perspectives, apart from a main essay by Nikhil Naz, Consulting Editor, Sports, India Today TV. When the other G20 of nations was held recently in Delhi, it went under the motto *'vasudhaiva kutumbakam'*. The boys can be boys out in the middle and fight till the last ball. But in the stadia and every other public space, we need to play graceful hosts again and live up to the other Indian dictum: *'atithi devo bhava'* (the guest be treated like God). We can still root for India by saying: May the best team win, but if our Boys in Blue do bring the cup home, it will be one more tribute to a Rising India.



(Aroon Purie)